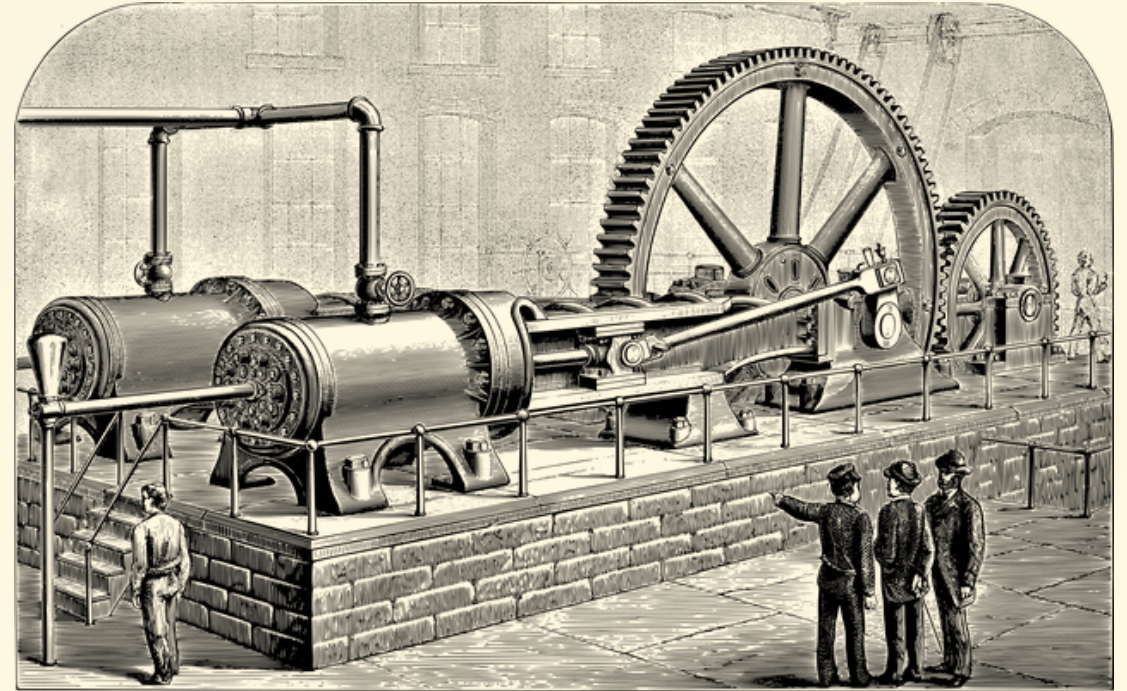


ECO 331

Economic History

Introduction

Jonathan Conning
Spring 2026



Required Texts

- Koyama, Mark, Rubin, Jared, 2022. *How the World Became Rich: The Historical Origins of Economic Growth*. John Wiley & Sons.
- Galor, Oded, 2022. *The Journey of Humanity: The Origins of Wealth and Inequality*. Penguin.

Reasonably priced in e-book, print, and/or audio formats.

Canvas LMS

canvas.instructure.com/enroll/P9XDGD

- Syllabus, Reading Schedule
- Threaded Discussions
- Homework and grades
- free

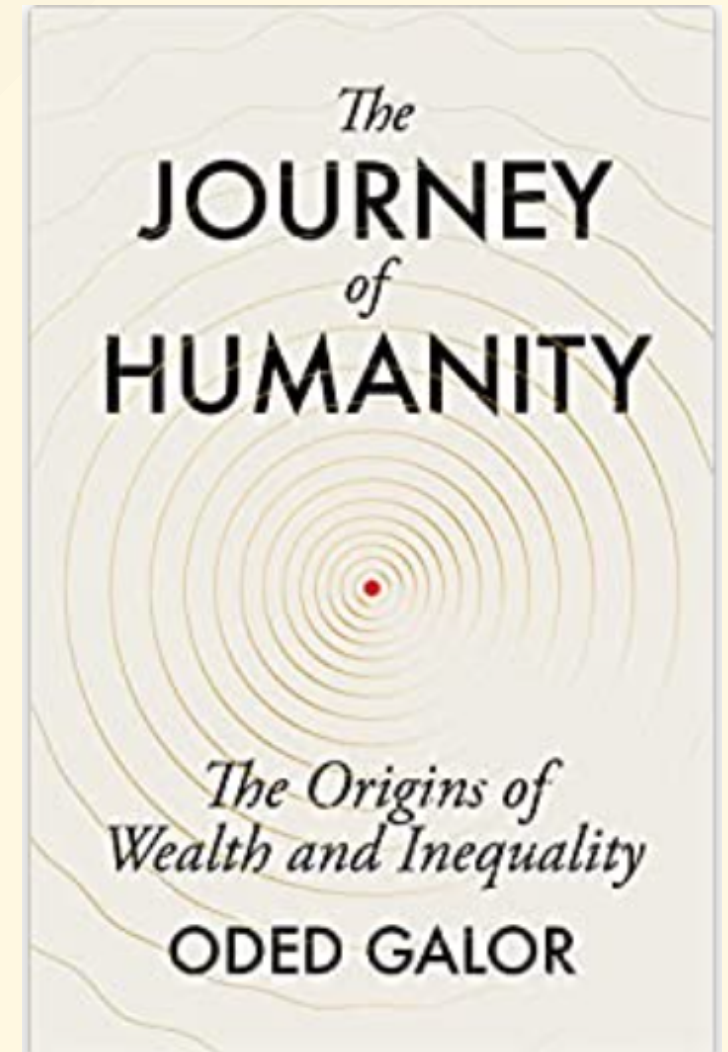
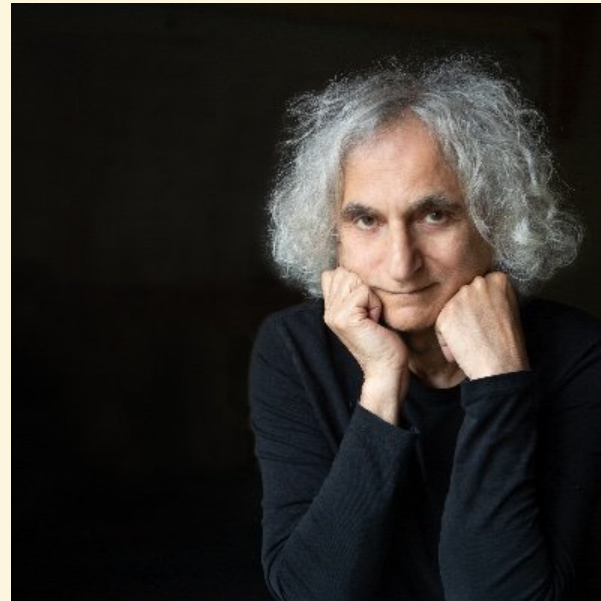


Grading



Activity	pct
Discussion/Participation	35 %
Midterm	20 %
Article/Chapter Report	15 %
Final Exam	30 %

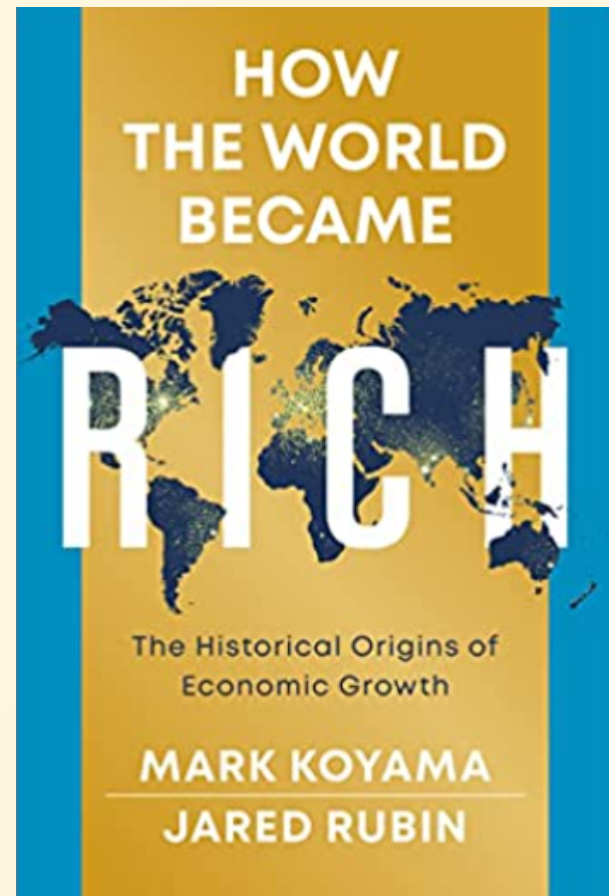
Oded Galor
Brown University



Unified Growth Theory

Oded Galor





Mark Koyama
(GWU)

Jared Rubin
(Chapman
Univ)

'Big History' Questions

- How did the world become Rich?
- Why did it take so long?
- Why did it happen first in some places before others?
- Why isn't the whole world rich?

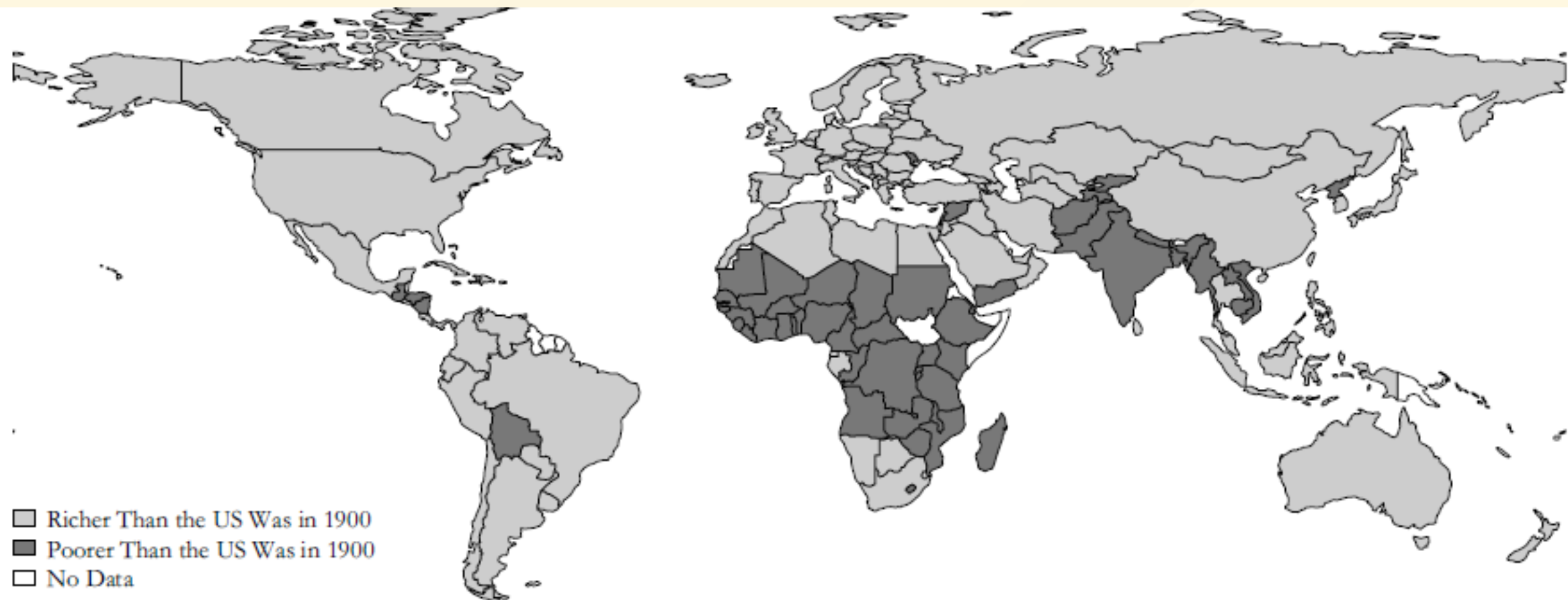


Figure 1.1 Countries that were richer in 2018 (annual per capita income) than the US in 1900
Data source: Bolt and van Zanden (2020). Average income in the US in 1900 was \$8,970 in 2011 USD.

Transitions

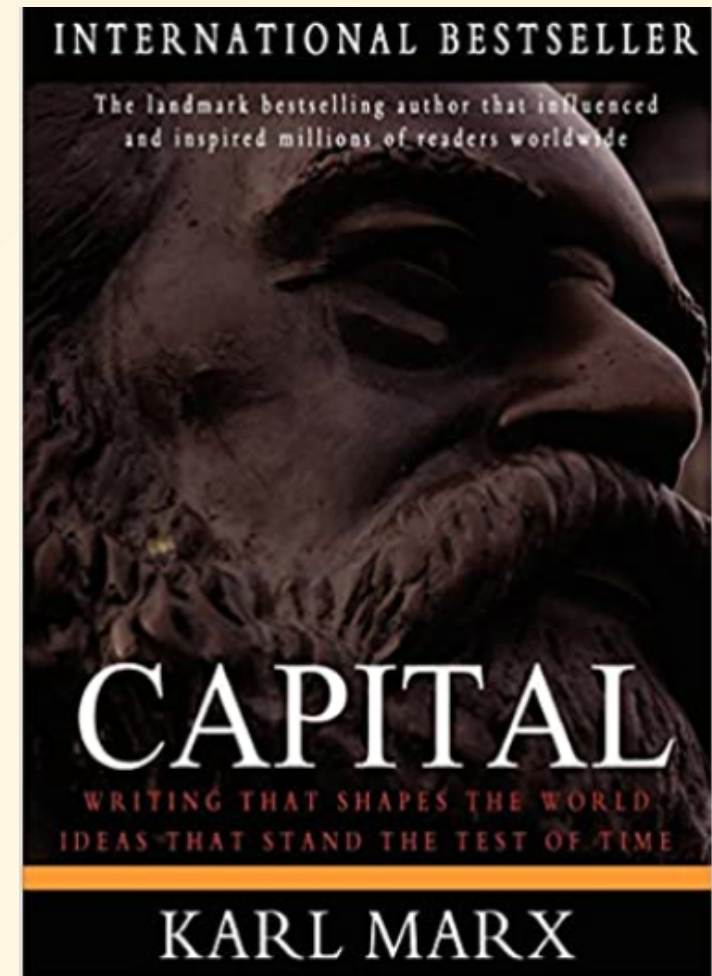
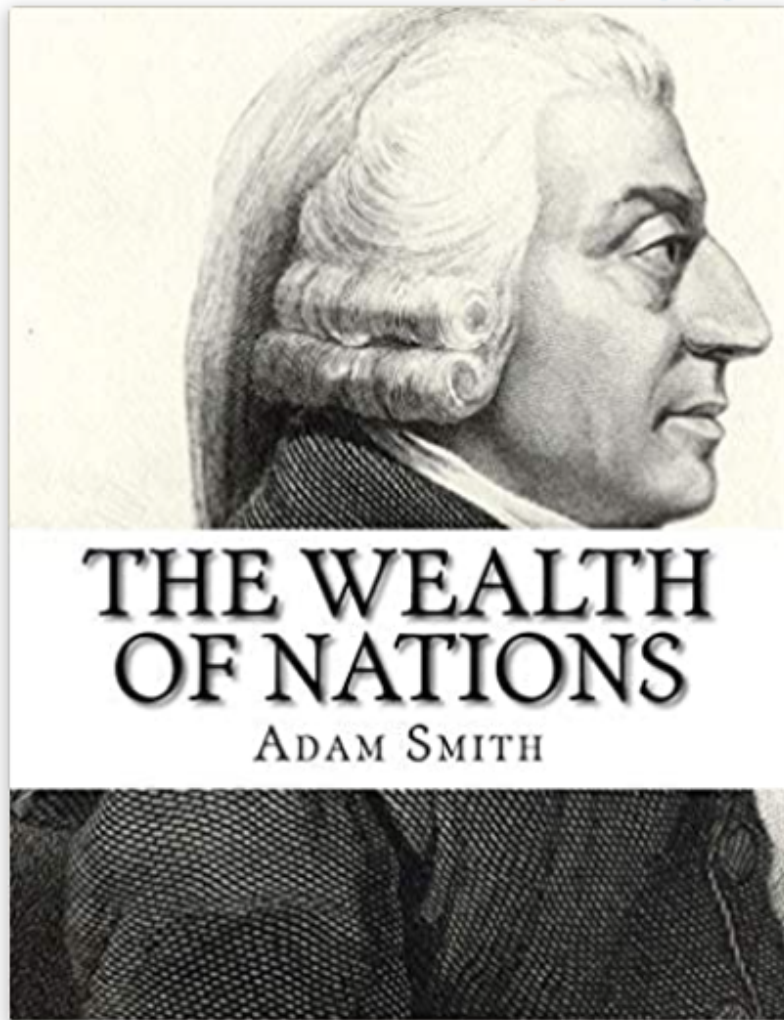
- The Neolithic Revolution
- Early States, Empires
- Malthusian Trap
- Rise and Fall of Feudalism

Transitions (continued)

- Capitalist Transitions
 - The enclosure of lands
 - The rise of cities, Modern States
 - Demographic Transitions. Malthusian escape
- Conquest, Colonization, Slavery
- The Industrial Revolution(s)
 - Firms, Technology R&D
 - Global Trade and Finance



Classical Political Economy



Barrington Moore, Jr.

SOCIAL ORIGINS OF DICTATORSHIP AND DEMOCRACY

With a new Foreword by Edward Friedman and James C. Scott

LORD AND PEASANT
IN THE MAKING OF
THE MODERN WORLD

"A profoundly important book."
- *New York Times Book Review*

WINNER OF THE PULITZER PRIZE

A MAJOR
PBS
SPECIAL

GUNS, GERMS, AND STEEL

The FATES of HUMAN SOCIETIES

JARED DIAMOND

WITH A NEW AFTERWORD

THE GREAT

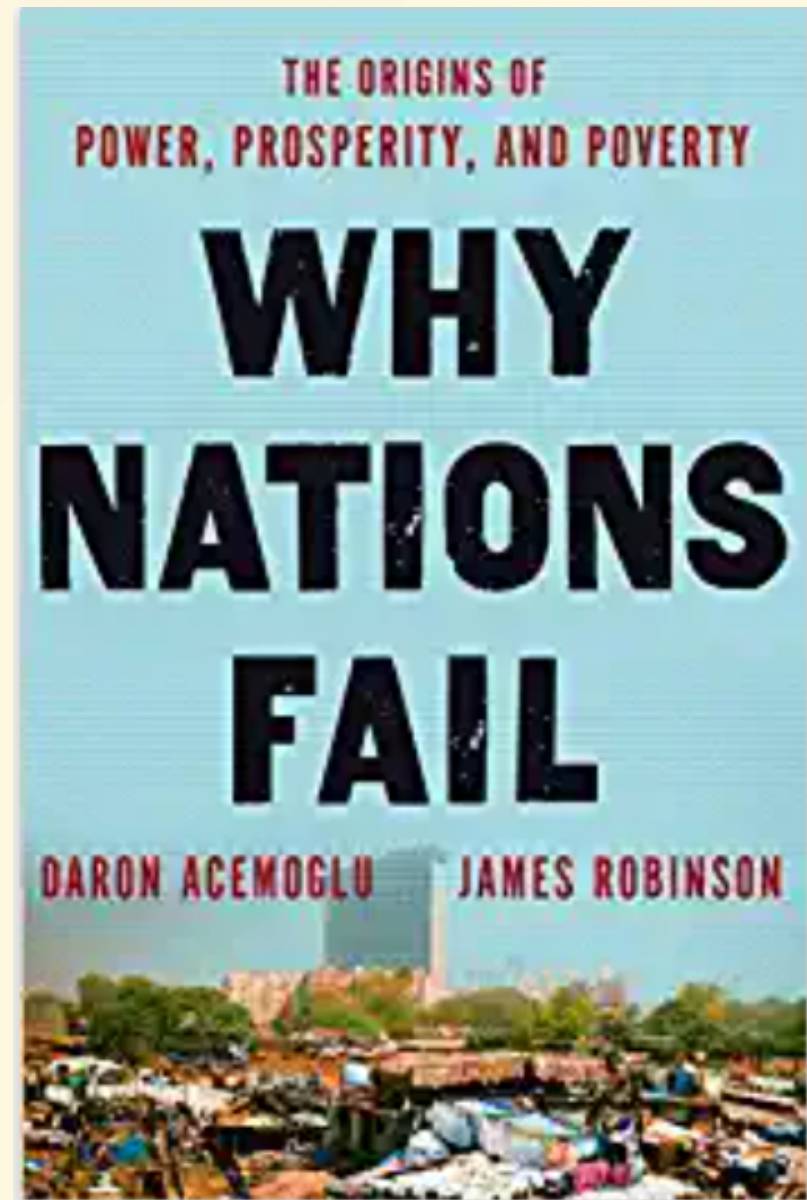
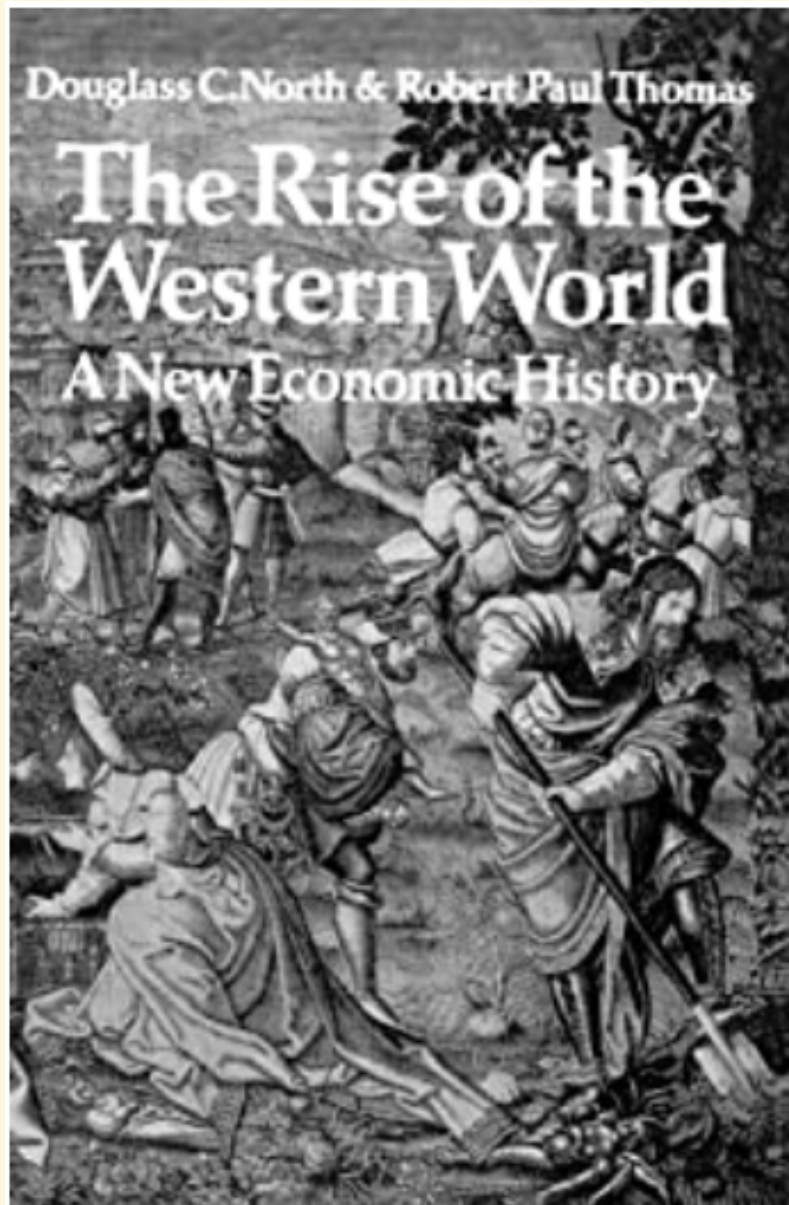
DIVERGENCE,

CHINA, EUROPE, AND THE MAKING OF
THE MODERN WORLD ECONOMY



KENNETH POMERANZ

With a new preface by the author



2025 Nobel Prize in Economics



- Joel Mokyr: “for having identified the prerequisites for sustained growth through technological progress.”
- Aghion and Howitt: “for the theory of sustained growth through creative destruction.”

2024 Nobel Prize in Economics

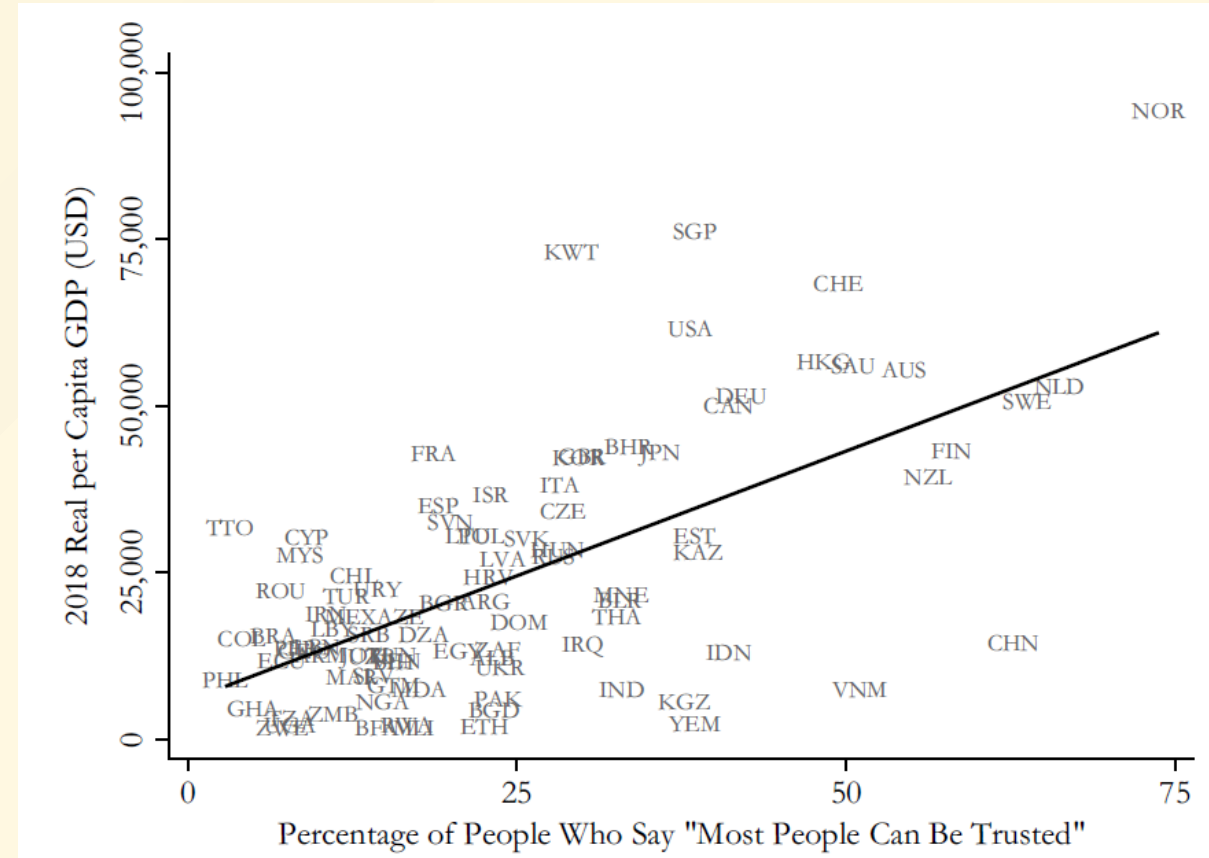
"for studies of how institutions are formed and affect prosperity"





Causal Mechanisms

- Proximate versus Fundamental Causes
- Causal Relationships vs. Correlations
- Exogenous vs Endogenous
- Can we identify causal relationships?



KR's Explanation Categories

- Did Some Societies Win the Geography Lottery?
- Is it All Just Institutions?
- Did Culture Make Some Rich and Others Poor?
- Fewer Babies?
- Was it Just a Matter of Colonization and Exploitation?



This Week

Tuesday/Thursday: Introduction

- OG, "Mysteries of the Human Journey" (1-10)
- OG 1 "First Steps," (13-25).
- Henrich, Joseph (2017) "Chapter 1: A Puzzling Primate"
- KR 1, "Why, When, and How Did the World become rich" (1-16)

Next and every week, due the night (8am) before class

- **Two questions**

- One factual/conceptual
- One probing, to take the conversation in interesting directions.

- **Two comments**

- Agree or disagree, reframe, etc.
- Historical observation or trivia

Submit via Canvas. Due 11pm the night before class.

- **Student Led presentations**

- Groups of 4. Responsible for short slide deck, typically on additional reading.

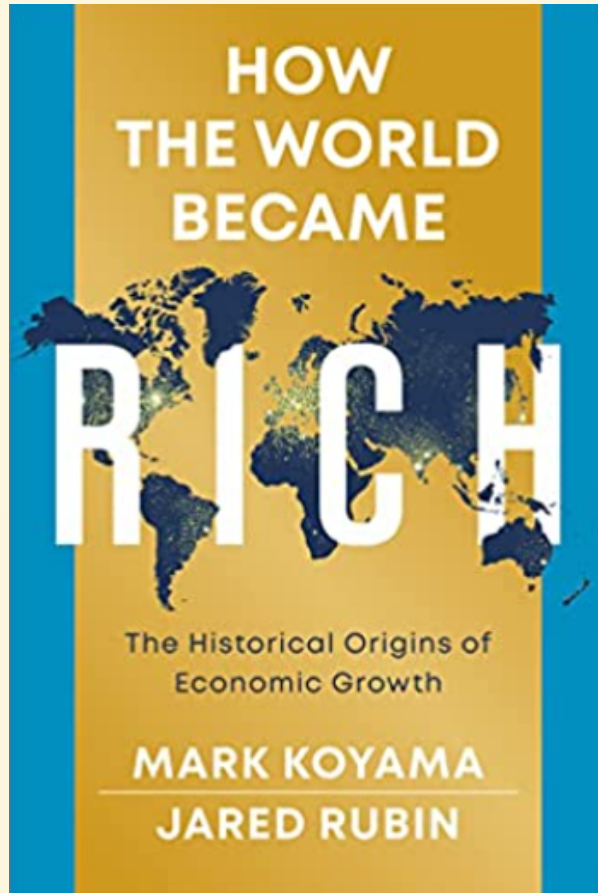
Introductions

- Your name (nickname?)
- Major/minor
- Interests in economic history.
- Anything else interesting about yourself.

Chapter 1

Why, When, and How

Did the World Become Rich?



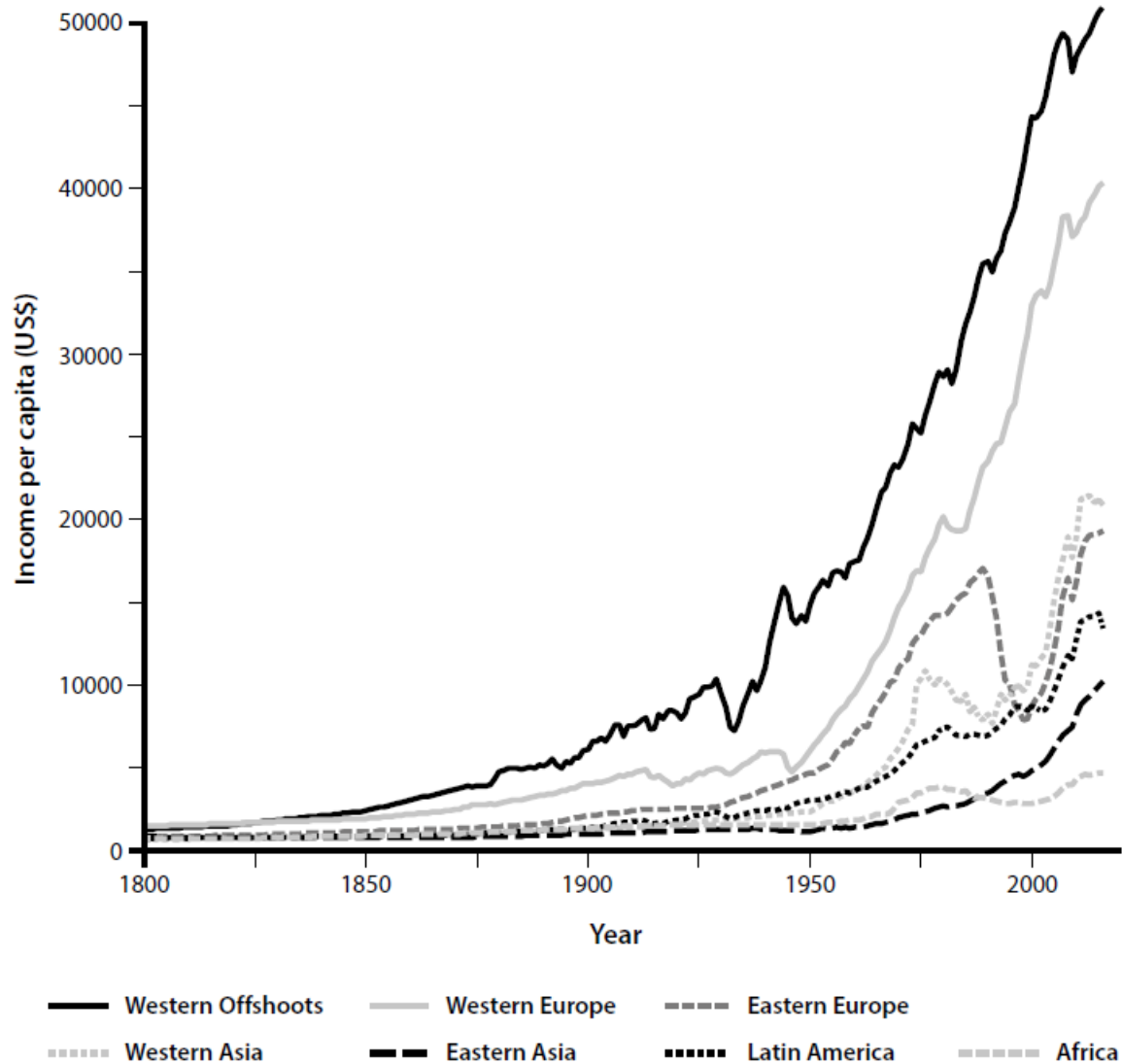


Figure 2. The Mystery of Inequality

The divergence in per capita income across world regions in the past two centuries.⁷

- What does GDP measure?
Same as income?
- Methods
 - GDP stats and deflators
 - PPP
 - Consumption baskets
 - Correlates
 - Height
 - Life Expectancy
- Are these the right measures?
 - what left out?

Growth

- Does growth bring other values?
 - What other values?
 - Tradeoffs?
- Growth vs Development
- Sustained economic growth
 - Efflorescences
 - Shrinkages

KR's list of theories

- Geography
- Institutions and Politics
- Culture
- Demographics
- Colonization and Exploitation

Non-monocausal

Contingent

Identification challenges

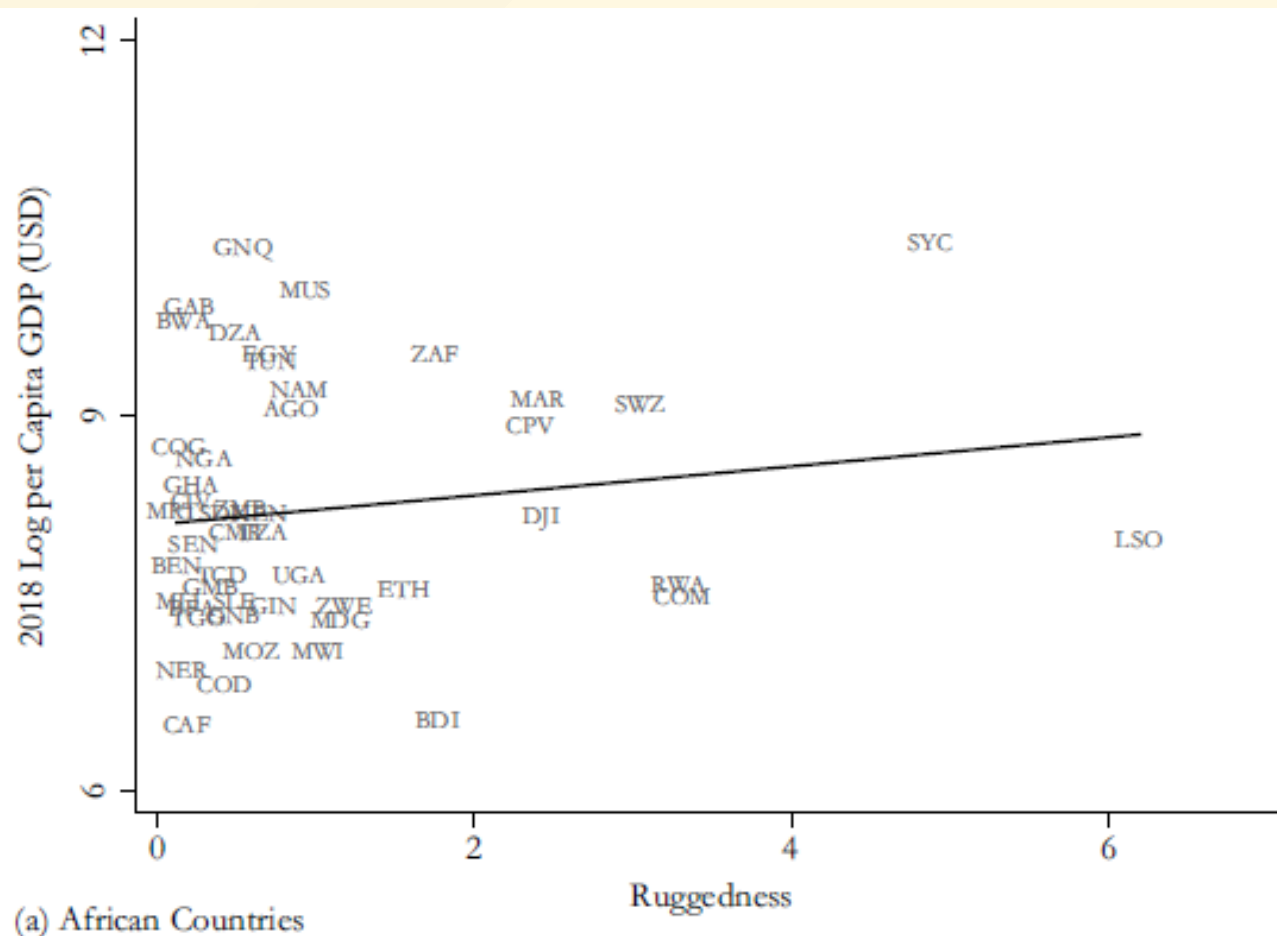
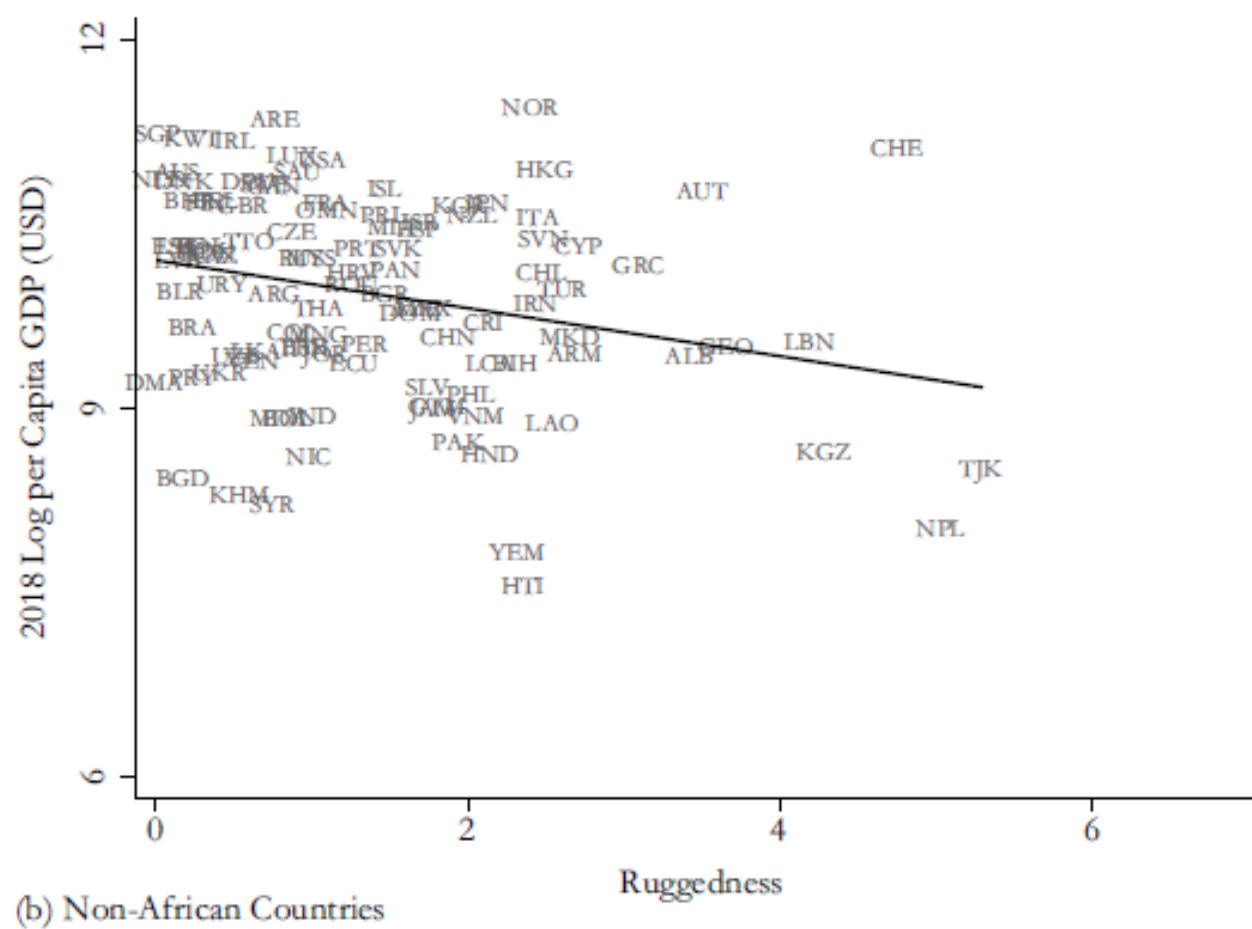
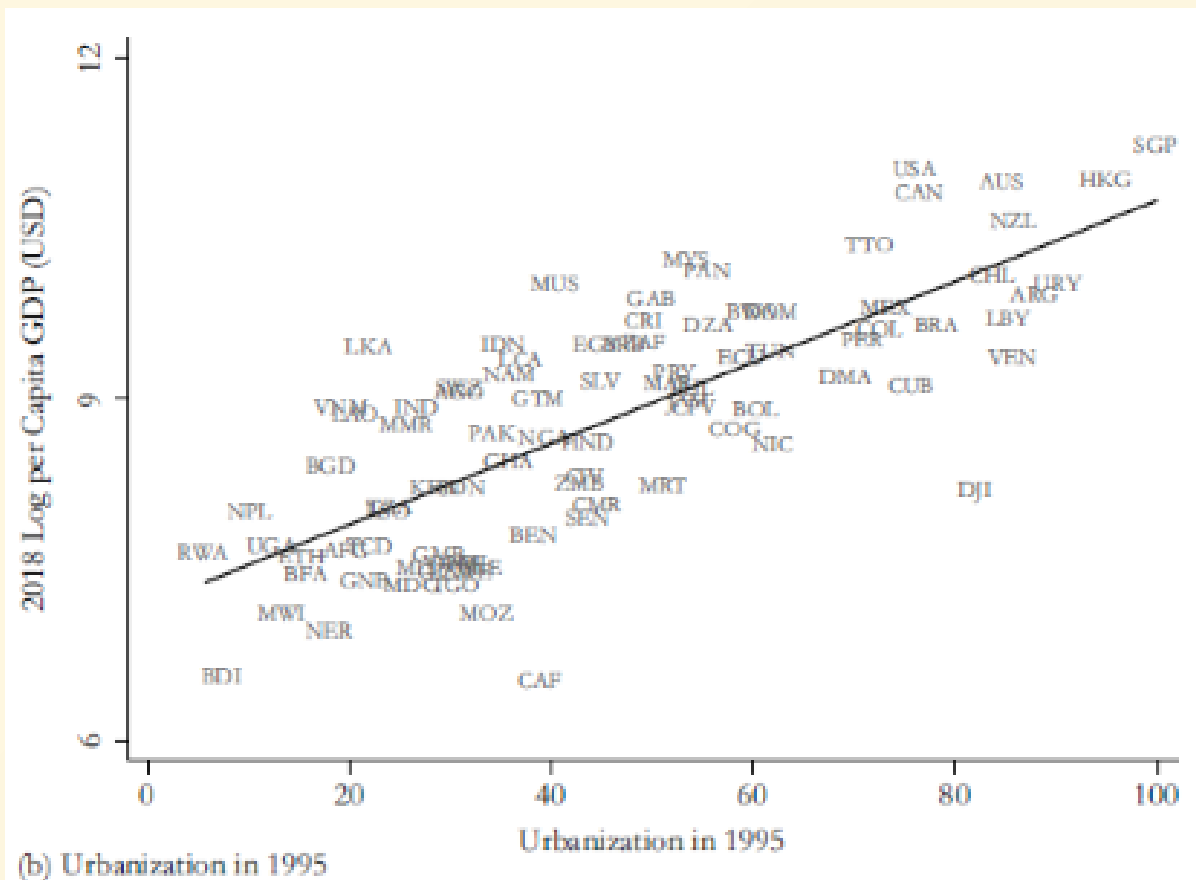


Figure 1.7 Ruggedness and income in African and non-African countries

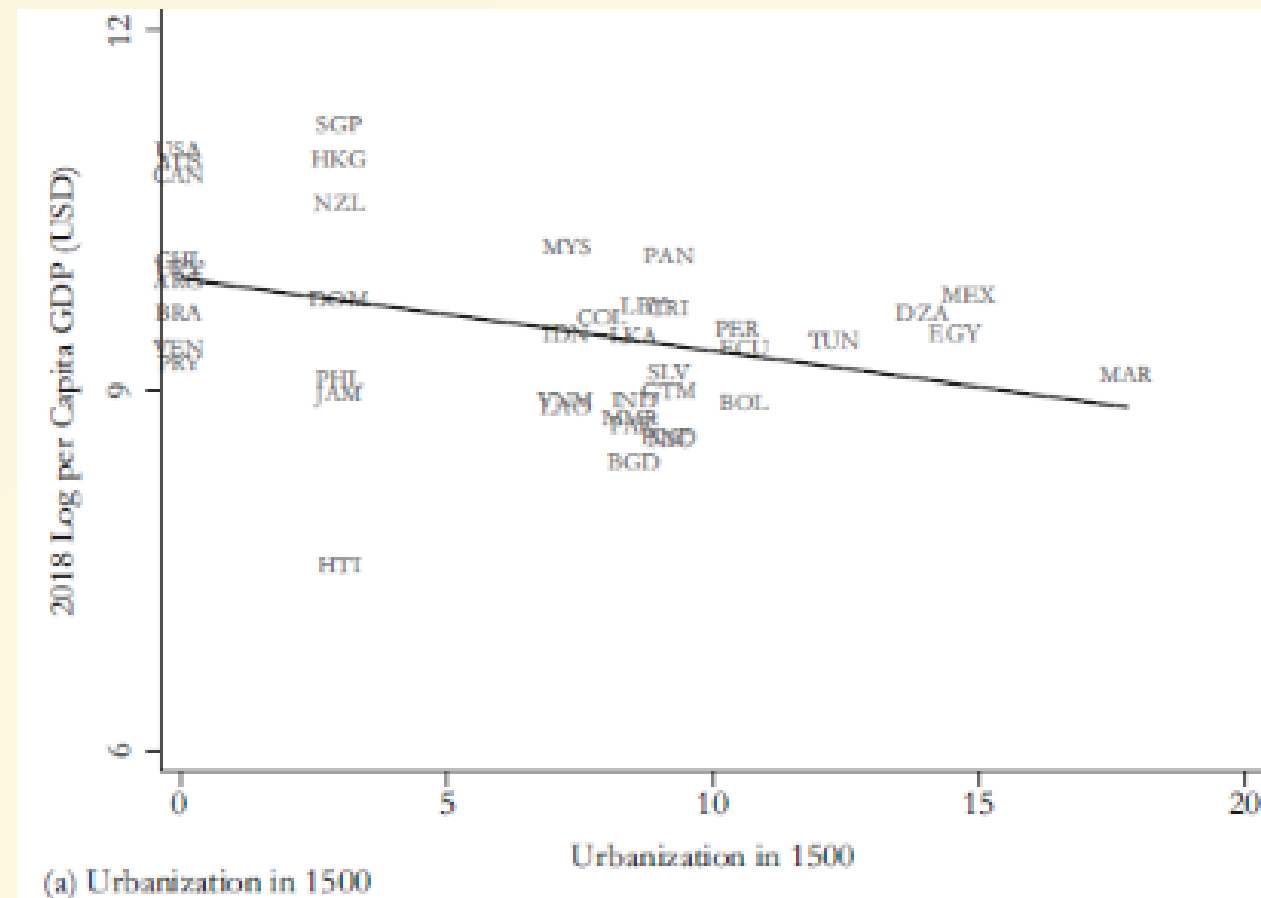
Data sources: Nunn and Puga (2012) for ruggedness, Bolt and van Zanden (2020) for GDP per capita.



(b) Urbanization in 1995

Figure 1.8 The reversal of fortunes within formerly colonized nations, 1500–1995

Data sources: Acemoglu, Johnson, and Robinson (2002) for urbanization, Bolt and van Zanden (2020) for GDP per capita.



What Makes Humans Different?

A Puzzling Primate (Henrich)

- Physically weak, slow, poor climbers
- Any chimp can overpower us.
- Yet we spread to every terrestrial ecosystem on Earth
- From frozen Siberia to arid deserts to tropical rainforests

The puzzle: How did the world's most physically vulnerable primate become the most successful?

Video Title

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src="https://www.youtube.com/embed/PNrWUS13th8" frameborder="0"  
allowfullscreen></iframe>
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Culture: Our Secret Superpower

Humans are a cultural species

- We learn from each other
- Knowledge accumulates across generations
- Skills improve and compound over time

Unlike other animals, humans can:

- Build on previous generations' discoveries
- Transmit complex knowledge through language
- Solve problems that no individual could figure out alone

Culture makes us smart. We are not smart because our species is innately brilliant; we are smart because we have culturally evolved vast tools and knowledge.

Language & Symbolic Thought

Language enables:

- Precise communication of complex ideas
- Storage of knowledge beyond individual memory
- Teaching of abstract concepts
- Cooperation at unprecedented scales

Without language:

- Fire, cooking, tools would not accumulate
- Each generation would start from scratch
- We could not maintain the body of knowledge needed to survive new environments

Language is uniquely human - our capacity for grammar, symbols, and abstract thought sets us apart fundamentally from all other species.

Tools, Technology & Cumulative Innovation

From Henrich: Culture-Gene Coevolution

Humans have evolved the capacity to:

- Make and use increasingly complex tools
- Learn through demonstration and imitation
- Transmit technological knowledge intergenerationally

Examples of cumulative cultural packages:

- Fire and cooking (requires knowledge transmission)
- Fishing nets and boats (requires multiple integrated skills)
- Shelters adapted to local environments
- Food preparation and preservation techniques
- Hunting strategies and weapons

Global Expansion: A Recent Phenomenon

Tens of thousands of years ago, humans migrated across the globe:

- Crossed land bridges to Australia (40,000+ years ago)
- Reached the Arctic and subarctic (20,000+ years ago)
- Adapted to every major terrestrial ecosystem
- Developed specialized technologies for each environment

The Malthusian Reality:

- For nearly 300,000 years, per capita income barely rose above subsistence
- Plagues and famines were abundant
- 25% of babies did not reach their first birthday
- Life expectancy rarely exceeded 40 years
- Population growth offset all technological gains